

Hassan Sayed

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Employment

Center for Global Development

2025-

Postdoctoral Scholar, Market Shaping Accelerator (× Dartmouth, UChicago).

My research with MSA focuses on the theoretical design of public policies that promote socially-beneficial innovation in areas of climate and public health. Additionally, I work with nonprofit and government partners to inform the practical implementation of these policies.

Education

Princeton University

2019-25

PhD in Economics. Fields: Economic Theory, Political Economy.

Northwestern University

2015-19

B.A. in Economics, Mathematics, Mathematical Methods in the Social Sciences.

References

Professor Leah Boustan
Department of Economics
Yale University
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Professor Ilyana Kuziemko
Department of Economics
Princeton University
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Professor Pietro Ortoleva
Department of Economics
Princeton University
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Working Papers

1. [“Learning Traps.”](#) 2025. **Revise and Resubmit, American Journal of Political Science.**

When constituents are uncertain about whether leaders’ policy preferences align with their interests, policy choices generate a tradeoff between payoffs and information. Leaders can experiment with their preferred policy, but if the outcome is bad, constituents learn this and threaten office removal. I use a repeated model of political agency to analyze how this tradeoff shapes long-lived, term-unlimited leaders’ policy choices. When there is uncertainty about the optimal policy for constituents, leaders implement “learning traps”: spatially intermediate policies that halt learning about what the best policy is. They experiment only when their preferences are very likely to be aligned with constituents, a contrast to the “gambling for resurrection” logic ubiquitous in the literature. I provide a case study that examines how the 1861 reforms ending serfdom in Imperial Russia represented the logic of a “learning trap” and illustrate additional applications of the model to political contagion and economic policymaking.

2. [“Persuasion with Partisanship: The Informational Content of Policymaking with Application to US Governors.”](#) 2025.

I study a model where a political executive's policy agenda generates information about her ability. Since policies favoring a single party are harder to pass, the partisanship of an agenda influences what success or failure of passage communicates about ability. The model delivers a U-shape relationship between an executive's ex-ante winning chances and her agenda's partisanship. Executives likely to lose pursue partisan policies to save their winning chances. Those likely to win embrace partisan policies whose failure can be blamed on the legislature. Those in the middle pursue bipartisan policies to secure reelection. I use these insights to analyze the partisanship of U.S. governors' policy proposals from 1990-2020, showing that while partisanship has risen on average, there is sizeable variation at the governor level. I interpret these variations as responses to electoral incentives by testing the model and showing a U-shaped relationship between partisanship and approval ratings.

3. **"Transgressions in Organizations."** With Kim Sarnoff. 2025.

We study an organizational model where managers commit workplace against employees, or "transgressions." Employees can report transgressive managers for investigation and possible punishment. When employees' disutility from transgressions is low, we show that policies that disincentivize managers from committing transgressions — increasing the size of manager punishment, the ease of reporting, or the efficacy of investigation technology — may harm employees. These policies may motivate managers to commit harmful actions that employees do not want to report or induce managers to opt out of interacting with employees altogether. We provide a dynamic extension where reports generate information for the organization and employees, showing that the model converges to a steady state where employees are worse off than initially, harmful actions are never punished, and no organizational learning occurs.

4. **"A New Interpretation of Productivity Growth Dynamics in the Pre-Pandemic and Pandemic-Era U.S. Economy, 1950-2023."** With Robert J. Gordon. 2024. NBER WP 30267, CEPR DP19569.

This paper provides a unified framework that resolves why productivity growth in 2010-19 was some of the slowest in American history, why its cyclical changed from procyclical in 1950-85 to acyclical in 1986-2006 to procyclical in 2010-19, and why it was strongly countercyclical in the recessions of 2008-09 and 2020. The fundamental dynamic driving cyclical productivity fluctuations originates in the gradual adjustment of hours of work to demand-driven output fluctuations due to labor frictions. We are able to explain the temporary 1986-2006 disappearance of procyclicality as the result of changes in the standard deviation and serial correlation of output changes. We explain countercyclical productivity surges in 2008-09 and 2020 by showing that business firms in those two episodes overreacted with "excess layoffs," cutting hours in response to the sharp output decline with a much higher elasticity than normal. By coupling these excess layoffs with a post-recession rehiring effect that gradually unwound the excess layoffs, our regression analysis explains why productivity growth on average was so slow in 2010-19. In the absence of excess layoffs, productivity growth in the 2010-19 decade would have been 1.9 percent per year instead of 1.1 percent, suggesting that concern about U.S. "secular stagnation" has been overstated.

Selected Work in Progress

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1. “Push vs. Pull Funding and Optimal Innovation Policy” (slides available on request)

Suppose a funder can pay multiple firms that attempt to develop a socially beneficial innovation. If she wants to maximize the probability of developing the innovation, should she pursue “push funding” — such as unconditional research grants — or “pull-funding” — such as prizes or advance-market-commitments? I derive generic conditions in a heterogeneous, multi-firm setting under which pull funding is cheaper than push for a given target probability of success. While pull funding allows firms to capture information rents, it also allows funders to screen in highly efficient firms. Pull is cheaper if the target probability is modest or firm markets are sufficiently large. I provide practical tools for policymakers interested in designing push and pull policies.

2. “Learning from Blackboxes”

Consider a principal who contracts an agent for a recommendation. The agent utilizes a model and data to provide this recommendation. However, this model is a “blackbox” for the principal; she does not understand the data or the model. I provide bounds for learning from these “blackboxed” models, and show that the value of black-boxed models for the principal depends on the structure of her objective function. I explore applications of these findings to the adoption of artificial intelligence in the workplace and subcontracting in organizations.

3. “Inference from Choices and Spatial Differentiation” (slides available upon request)

Producers or politicians can differentiate themselves horizontally (in product/policy spaces) or vertically (in quality space). Consumers and voters make inferences about products or politicians by observing others’ choice data — such as who won an election or who purchased a product — but without observing others’ information. I show how career concerns distort producers’ (or politicians’) willingness to horizontally differentiate themselves from the competition, particularly in settings of dynamic choice, leading to convergence on inefficient policies.

4. “Model-Based Inference” (with Kim Sarnoff)

How do everyday Americans make inferences about causal processes underlying economic outcomes? This experimental project uses a “coefficient weight” method to elicit how participants create mental models that organize data.

Publications

1. “Transatlantic Technologies: The Role of ICT in the Evolution of U.S. and European Productivity Growth.” With Robert J. Gordon. *International Productivity Monitor* No. 38, Spring 2020.
2. “The Industry Anatomy of the Transatlantic Productivity Growth Slowdown: Europe Chasing the American Frontier.” With Robert J. Gordon. *International Productivity Monitor* No. 37, Fall 2019.

Teaching

Princeton	SPI 511b: Microeconomic Analysis for Policymakers (TA, Fall 2024)
Northwestern	MATH 220: Single-Variable Calculus (TA: Fall 2016)
	MATH 224: Single-Variable Integral Calculus (TA: Winter 2017, Fall 2017)
	MATH 230: Multivariable Calculus (TA: Spring 2018, Winter 2019)

Honors, Scholarships, Fellowships, and Grants

National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship	2019–24
Research Program in Political Economy Grant, Princeton	2024
William S. Dietrich II Economic Theory Center Research Grant	2022–24
Princeton University Graduate Fellowship	2019–21
Frederick S. Deibler Award for Distinguished Honors Thesis, Northwestern	2019
Interdisciplinary Honors, Northwestern	2019
Phi Beta Kappa, Northwestern	2019

Other Research Experience

2022	Research Assistant, Prof. Roland Bénabou (Princeton)
2017–19	Research Assistant, Prof. Robert J. Gordon (Northwestern)

Professional Activities

Presentations (incl. scheduled)

2025	36 th Stony Brook International Conference on Game Theory, European Winter Meeting of the Econometric Society, Princeton Microeconomic Theory, Princeton Political Economy
2024	Princeton Industrial Relations Seminar, Princeton Microeconomic Theory, Princeton Political Economy
2023	North American Summer Meetings of the Econometrics Society, Princeton Microeconomic Theory, Princeton Political Economy
2022	Association for Comparative Economic Studies, Princeton Microeconomic Theory, Princeton Political Economy, Young Economist Symposium
2021	Princeton Microeconomic Theory

Referee Services

American Economic Review

News Articles

1. "Transatlantic Technologies: The Role of ICT in the Evolution of U.S. and European Productivity Growth." With Robert J. Gordon. *International Productivity Monitor* No. 38, Spring 2020.
2. "The Industry Anatomy of the Transatlantic Productivity Growth Slowdown: Europe Chasing the American Frontier." With Robert J. Gordon. *International Productivity Monitor* No. 37, Fall 2019.

Skills and Activities

Languages	English, Urdu; MATLAB, Python, STATA
Citizenship	United States
Activities	Princeton Lawrence Apartments Committee (Secretary 2021-22, President 2022-24); Adobe Creative Suite; Professional Photography

Last updated: July 2025